

King of the engine room wins Ballon d'Or

On a night when Real Madrid chose to boycott the ceremony, Rodri's win carved a new path of **inspiration for midfielders.**

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For the last 18 years, the Ballon d'Or has mainly gone to forwards, as Lionel Messi and Cristiano Ronaldo battled for the top honours. Goals, hat-tricks, and assists became synonymous with the illustrious Golden Ball.

This year, yet another forward, Vinicius Junior, was tipped for the award, but the votes defied expectations as the Brazilian ultimately had to contend with second place.

Instead, Rodrigo Hernandez — known globally as Rodri — claimed the men's Ballon d'Or, becoming only the second defensive midfielder to win the trophy after Lothar Matthaus in 1990. The pernicious bias towards attacking players was finally broken.

Nine goals, 14 assists, and four major trophies for club and country in the 2023-24 season placed him at the top as the best player in the world.

As shouts in favour of Vinicius and hateful discontent for his loss echoed outside the venue in Paris,

Rodri, in his speech, instead focused on love.

"Today is a special day, not just for me but for my family. First of all, I have to thank a very special person, my girlfriend Laura [Iglesias]; today is our eighth anniversary. Without her, things would not be the same," he said.

Rodri underlined the legacy of Spanish midfielders who missed out on the trophy during the Messi-Ronaldo era.

"Today is not a victory for me; it is for Spanish football and for so many players who have not won it and have deserved it, like Iniesta, Xavi, Iker [Casillas], Sergio Busquets, and so many others. It is for Spanish football and the figure of the midfielder," Rodri said.

Tiki-taka, Spain's trademark style, was crafted in midfield, a tradition upheld by the likes of Xavi, Iniesta and Busquets, and passed to the next generation — the finest example being Manchester City's Rodri.

While there are other Spanish players who have adopted the philosophy of Xavi and Iniesta, such as Pedri and Gavi, Rodri's towering and physical presence became the key to ending Spain's decade-long trophy drought. **Although coach Luis Enrique initially used him as a central defender, Rodri reached peak form as Spain's midfield pivot, succeeding Busquets after his retirement.**

His presence brought balance to Spain's midfield, under head coach Luis de la Fuente, paving the path for Spain to secure its first major double — the UEFA Nations League and the 2024 European Championship — since its World Cup and Euro double in 2012.

Under Pep Guardiola, Manchester City formed a team of champions, culminating in a historic treble in the 2022-23 season. One of the most consistent players on that team was

